change in light of new information. However, Indian leaders have to deal with factions within their own political parties, with opposition parties that could challenge them in elections, and with the media and public protests. Chinese leaders are to a greater degree insulated from these pressures, but they face rivals within the CPC. While they do not need to worry about an opposition party or traditional media, they must keep an eye on social media platforms which even Beijing cannot altogether control. And China has a history of street protests, even if these go unreported in its media. The differences in the two political systems suggest that the constraining effect of domestic politics is more severe in India, but even as dominant a leader as Xi in contemporary China will find it difficult to give away what ordinary Chinese regard as their territory.

What does the future hold? The lack of trust and effective communication, the zero-sum view of security, the persistence of cognitive dissonance, and weak leadership that marked an earlier era are still very much in evidence. The rising number of confrontations including in Ladakh in 2020 have done little to increase trust between India and China. Nor have the many summits and high-level meetings improved communication and belief in the other's word. Modi and Xi held two informal summits (2018, 2019). Yet Indian and Chinese forces came to blows in Galwan in 2020. A zero-sum view of security has meant that months after the 2020 incident, neither side has been willing to give up an inch of territory. As far as we know, Delhi and Beijing hold firmly to their overall claims across the entire border. It was again clear that the two sides are far apart on everything connected with border incidents – who encroached, when the encroachments happened and to what extent, how many casualties were incurred, what was agreed in the disengagement negotiations, who provoked the flare-ups, and so on. No amount of information exchanged between the two governments seems to have overcome the cognitive dissonance in both capitals: neither side has changed its views, going by their public reactions and responses. Modi's podium-thumping references to resisting outdated eighteenth-century 'expansionism' and Xi's fist-shaking insistence that China will protect its territorial integrity no matter what the